

What else to watch: *Dr. Mabuse the Gambler* (1922, p.330) ■ *Metropolis* (1927, pp.32–33) ■ *Fury* (1936) ■ *Ministry of Fear* (1944) ■ *The Beast with Five Fingers* (1946) ■ *The Big Heat* (1953, pp.332–33) ■ *While the City Sleeps* (1956)

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The tangled mind is exposed...
hatred of itself and despair
jumping at you from the jelly.

Graham Greene

”

fairground, the scene cuts to her anxious mother at home, then out of the window, then into the yard. Her calls become desperate over shots of absence: vacant rooms, an empty dinner plate. When the actual murder is committed, Lang shows nothing but the girl's ball rolling into the grass and a stray balloon floating away.

Beckert, the killer, seen only from behind, writes to the papers, protesting that the police are not publicizing his crimes. Instead of trailing Beckert, however, Lang cuts to the wider repercussions of the girl's murder. A reward is posted, and as the police pursue

The killer Hans Beckert (Peter Lorre) stares wide-eyed at his back, as he sees in the mirror that he has been marked with the letter “M.”

their investigations, the citizens plan their own justice. Vigilantism, a common theme in Lang's later career, becomes a major element of the story.

A human monster

Part of the power of *M* is the way in which Lang effortlessly wrong-foots the viewer. So meek is the monster at the heart of the story, when his face is finally revealed, that the audience is thrown off guard, put into his shoes and made to feel his fear. Lang then expertly cranks up the tension, with the killer unwittingly marked with a chalk letter “M,” for *Mörder* (murderer), and Beckert's distress increasing as the chase gathers momentum.

M was Lang's first “talkie,” and he makes incredible use of sound, and silence. The director subtly creates tension in the killer's very first entrance: as he is about to strike, Beckert whistles a familiar tune—to unsettling effect. Lang uses sound to different but equally



disturbing ends when Beckert is on the run, when the noise of fire-engine sirens and traffic create a disorienting cacophony.

Final judgment

M keeps nudging the audience off balance to the end. The movie's tension comes not only from the relentless ticktock of the narrative, but also from the question that Lang asks the audience: what kind of justice it wants to see for the killer. It's a sophisticated approach even now, let alone for an audience that would still have been acclimatizing to Lang's innovations with sound and subject matter. Lang himself—in a long career filled with truly great movies—always insisted that *M* was the finest of them all. ■



Fritz Lang Director

Born in Vienna in 1890, Fritz Lang made his directorial debut

at the German UFA studios with *Halbblut* (*The Weakling*) in 1919, about a man ruined by his love for a woman—a recurrent theme in his movies. After a series of hits, including science-fiction classic *Metropolis*, Lang made his masterpiece with *M*.

Impressed by his talent, the Nazis asked Lang to head the UFA studio in 1933. Instead, he fled to the US, where he forged a highly successful career. He died in 1976.

Key movies

1922 *Dr. Mabuse the Gambler*
1927 *Metropolis*
1931 *M*
1953 *The Big Heat*